

ASSAM MOVEMENT

■ By Sanjib Baruah

India's democratic institutions are often praised for their capacity to accommodate social movements that they bring into the political process. These include demands expressed through civil disobedience and the politics of the street. The Assam movement, which started in 1979 and ended in 1985, once seemed to be a stellar success of Indian democracy. But in retrospect its failures have become more apparent. The movement, led by the All Assam Students Union and the All Asom Gana Sangram Parishad, saw extraordinary mobilisation against illegal immigration and the enfranchisement of non-citizens that, cam-

paigners believed, risked turning the "indigenous" people of Assam into a political minority. It ended with an agreement between the Indian government and the movement leaders after which the Congress government, headed by Hiteshwar Saikia, resigned. In the elections that followed in 1985, the Asom Gana Parishad, led by Prafulla Kumar Mahanta, was voted to power.

That immigrants from Bangladesh constitute a large segment of Assam's population was never in dispute. British officials viewed Assam as one of the subcontinent's last frontiers to be settled by immigrants. The Partition of 1947 could not stop the flow,

Call to ARMS

The anti-foreigner agitation caused fissures between Hindus and Muslims, triggered mutinies by tribal groups including Bodos, and created the ULFA

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

UNITED WE STAND: AASU leader Prafulla Mahanta (second from left) in Delhi for talks with Union home secretary in 1985

